

Respiratory Rate

When visiting the doctor, they check for these vital signs: temperature, blood pressure, pulse and respiratory rate and so on, but we'll be focusing on the respiratory rate. According to [lung.org](https://www.lung.org), the number of breaths an individual takes per minute is classified as your Respiratory Rate (RR). Medical staff, either the doctor or nurse, typically measure this by watching the patient's chest rising (inhaling) and falling (exhale) while they rest. One of the first signs that a patient is in distress is the change in respiratory rate, this is due to the fact that breathing is mainly controlled by the brain based on the body's need to get rid of carbon dioxide and the need for oxygen.

The normal respiratory rate for healthy adults is between 12-20 breaths per minute. Patients whose breathing exceeds 20 breaths per minute would be classified as having tachypnea, which happens when the body is working overtime to get more oxygen in to the body and expel excess acid, that usually occurs during infections, high fevers (febrile) or when a patient is experiencing anxiety. On the other hand, if the respiratory rate falls below that 12 breaths per minute, a patient could be experiencing bradypnea. This occurs if a patient uses heavy medications like sedatives and narcotics but in more serious cases, this can be a sign of a head injury or hypothermia.

What does this mean for triaging? Respiratory rate is a powerful tool in the triage setting as it helps detect critical illnesses in patients early. For example a high respiratory rate, as mentioned before, detects the worsening of a patient's wellbeing, which often signals serious conditions like pneumonia, sepsis (a severe infection response), or even heart failure. Alternately, a dangerously low respiratory rate is an immediate emergency as a patient can stop breathing altogether. Therefore, triage nurses rely heavily on the respiratory rate to quickly spot patients who are in need of urgent help.

References

Understanding Vital Signs: The Importance of Your Respiratory Rate. (2025, August 19).

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